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Amusement and absolution

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Document Type: Article

Original Page: 832

Culture (OWC): [Okiek \(FL20\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1974, 1982, 1988

Coverage Date: 1974-1988

Place Coverage

Kaplelach and Kipchornwonek Okiek, Mau Escarpment, Narok district, Rift Valley province, Kenya

Section Title(S)

Mortal and Immortal Threats: Pain, Damnation, and Shame

The concept of personhood that emerges from *pesenweek*, then, is fundamentally relational (cf. Jackson 1989:106). Faults lie not in personal imperfection but in how one interacts with others. Proper interaction is determined by types of social relations, for example, between children and adults, between children and other children, or between men and women. These social categories define a set of related notions of self differing in abilities, rights, and expectations. Some are linked in the developmental progression of maturation, while others posit intrinsic, "natural" distinctions of ability and being.

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This is rather different from an understanding where children and adults are equally imperfect, equally responsible for eternal repercussions of their own actions, and equally striving to control their behavior, intentions, and, through that, their salvation. Similarly, notions of agency and blame in Okiek *pesenweek* differ from the individually oriented ones of Western confession. Complicity in both agency and blame again underline the relational character central to personhood.

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A complicated cycle of reciprocal action, reaction, and interaction is involved in the agency of *pesenweek*. The child instigates a *pesenta* through disrespect and disobedience, but the actual threat originates in the adult's grudgeful anger. Adult threats make the child's confession necessary, but the child disarms threats through confession. In the end, the adult forgives and

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annoints. There are no explicit gradations of *pesenweek*, no steps of individual improvement or degeneration. *Pesenweek* are not events of individuals.

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Responsibility too is shared, but not only because of the complicated interrelations of agency. This partnership becomes clearer as confessions proceed. As *pesenweek* are told and then announced, blame shifts subtly from child to adult. The shift is accomplished in part through formal transformations in *pesenweek* narratives to be discussed below. Notions of personhood also play an important part in it.

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If adults make controlled, responsible decisions and children are still largely incapable of or excused from this, how do such arguments arise between adult and child in the first place? Even if provoked by the child, then, the adult is shown up: he lost his sense of appropriate behavior and became threateningly annoyed over a slight matter. Some examples, in fact, demonstrate not only how trivial disagreements can be, but also that the child refused quite legitimately and reasonably. Whether righteously angry or not, adults share blame in *pesenweek* for wanting vengeance on a mere child.

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Yet what sort of blame is this? As the focus and burden of blame shifts to adults named during *pesenweek* announcements, it melts away. The incident's triviality comes back into perspective; it becomes a laughing matter. Adults are usually more than willing scapegoats, adding to the hilarity with other comments. For them, the confession is a reminder of a trivial quarrel already faded, not a new provocation. Initiates suffer their blame in embarrassment at disclosing some intimate incidents, but that too is fleeting and soon forgotten. Childhood life, childish arguments, and blame are all left behind.

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Okiek notions of personhood, agency, and responsibility that emerge from *pesenweek* confessions, then, all entail an interactional foundation and a social definition. They also show certain contradictions that become clear during social interaction, for example, adults acting like irresponsible children and serious matters turning suddenly into jokes. By contrast, concepts central

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to Western confessional practice remain serious, inward-turning, and centered on a self more isolated and concerned with an independent immortal future. "Here the ethical subject was to be characterized ... by self-renunciation and a purity whose model was to be sought in virginity" (Foucault 1985:92).

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These quite different understandings of central cultural concepts have implications for confessional practice as well, for identifying who confesses, when, and how. Both call for confession with complete coverage, though with slightly different range. "Imagine how exorbitant must have seemed the order given to all Christians at the beginning of the  833 thirteenth century, to kneel at least once a year and confess all their transgressions, without omitting a single one" (Foucault 1980:60). Okiek initiates are also told to remember every *pesenta*, and then badgered to remember still more.

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